

Weekly 8

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Weekly Progress (5 points)

1. Settled on calibration for QCA for each of my variables based on the scale on which indicators were made and theory surrounding them – these are not final answers, but they’re good enough for right now, and I can adjust as I go.
2. Modified the conflict dataset to include a boolean outcome on the recurrence of war (defined just as whether or not there was continued fighting along the same lines, or whether the war terminated for some time after a cease fire or what have you). This is the dependent variable. Some of this work was dealing with annoying regex stuff to get it to get all start/end cols, but it’s all done now.
3. Hopefully put together a final dataset for one of the last times – unfortunately, some compromises were made (see challenges). This now includes the change in participatory democracy and change in GDP, as it’s important to recovery for people to feel like their situation is improving rather than just being “good” on some economic scale. It might be worth using the Gini index later for economic inequality or looking for more sophisticated measures than change in GDP per capita.
4. Performed calibration for my two datasets (one with substantial international involvement, one without), which wasn’t honestly a ton of code but could get messier later and did involve a decent amount of bug fixing since there’s few StackExchange stuff for this package. It’s kind of niche.
5. Performed the QCA and got preliminary results! I need to learn how to interpret them still, how I can modify it to get more info, and use some other data potentially, but fortunately, at this point, most of the coding work is done and it’s on to writing things up and modifying what I already have.

Challenges (3 points)

1. Unfortunately, in trying to get things to work for the QCA, I had to eliminate some data I planned to use. It would have restricted my dataset a little to include so much public opinion data, but I was willing to live with that, but upon implementing it I learned that the questions were varying too much between years for to use them without extensively consulting every survey wave’s codebook, which would take a *while* and be entirely manual. I can’t justify that right now, since I need to work on outputting something for certain, but it’s something to work on if I have time.
2. The calibration/deciding between crisp and fuzzy sets is something that is somewhat difficult for the time being, as I am having to set the parameters that will influence my conclusions, and I worry that how that calibration is done is impacting my preliminary results too much. I’m not sure how to conduct a sensitivity analysis for this sort of thing, so it’ll just be more reading.
3. Debugging code problems with the QCA package is a pain, as some of the error handling isn’t as specific or focused on what I’m doing as I would like, and frequently I would get errors that would involve the way that the package was actually programmed, which I am not familiar with. Everything was something I could handle, fortunately, but it’s a pain.

Code Commits (2 points)

1. Put together datasets for hopefully the last time, set up QCA:
<https://github.com/GW-datasci/26-spring-LUTZ-H/commit/511e8216619297fcac801fec448b1d6da4a334b3>
2. Performed preliminary QCA, setup for next time:
<https://github.com/GW-datasci/26-spring-LUTZ-H/commit/9d1f19cf673ff18369a1f22a674bf21c989dd0eb>